

Explanations for Varying Patterns of Political Incorporation Among Minority Groups in Ecuador

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Introduction

Historical patterns of state interaction with indigenous and Afro-descent minority groups in Ecuador have shaped how they interact with national politics today, but not uniformly. Both Andean indigenous communities and Afro-descendent communities have faced discrimination and exclusion, yet exhibit markedly different outcomes of political incorporation: indigenous groups interact with the state through autonomous, territorially rooted movements that can influence national politics, while Afro-descendent organizations have tended to be more fragmented, externally dependent, and less consistently present in formal institutions. This difference raises a central question: what causes have contributed to the differing patterns of political incorporation between Andean and Afro-descendent minority groups in Ecuador? In this paper, I will argue that there are three key factors that have caused this variation in political participation: historical mode of incorporation, origin of political institutions, and the group's relation to the state. In order to argue these points, I will use the MSSD approach to compare the similarities between the two cases, as well as accurately represent their divergence.

Background

Beginning in the early history of the territory, Spanish forces dominated and seized control of indigenous civilizations such as the Incas and others. By the 19th century, hacienda systems had expanded into indigenous lands, leaving indigenous people with small tracts of lands. On these haciendas, indigenous peasants were tied to the estates through a system called *huasipungo*, a form of debt-based servitude similar to feudalism. This continued into the 20th century. In 1930, the first peasant uprisings occurred when indigenous workers enacted a strike demanding higher wages and better working conditions on the haciendas. This resulted in the *Ley de Comunas*, which granted legal status to rural communities and their governing bodies, marking the beginnings of political autonomy of indigenous communities. Today, two political bodies dominate indigenous communal interaction with national politics: CONAIE and Pachakutik, which have garnered significant power in pushing for the protection of indigenous culture, rights, and land.

The history of Afro-descendent populations is less clear. While the exact number of imported slaves to Ecuador is unknown, the colonial government created entire territories and

economies based on slave labor in an effort to increase exports of agricultural products. These slaves were imported from west Africa and placed on plantations around the country. Following the abolition of slavery in Ecuador in 1851, ex-slaves congregated in communities not officially recognized by the government. Many ex-slaves continued to work in the agricultural and mining sectors in poor conditions for low wages. Unlike the Andean indigenous groups, Afro-descendants lacked territorial and cultural rights until the implementation of new constitutions in 1998 and 2008. Recently, key political institutions like CODAE (Afro-Ecuadorian Development Corporation) have been created through state-sponsorship and international development efforts. These organizations have failed to make sufficient impact on the nation's political sphere, as their funding has shifted and government priority has waned.

Literature

Scholarship on Latin American ethnic politics shows that collective mobilization and organizational autonomy within minority groups has a strong effect on political incorporation and developmental success. Donna Lee Van Cott (2005) demonstrates that in Ecuador, indigenous organizations such as CONAIE have helped indigenous communities transform their interests into political action with influence over national outcomes. Van Cott highlights the creation of autonomous political vehicles as a key avenue towards political incorporation, linking these organizations to greater representation in national legislature. Hiskey and Seligson (2003, 85) note that "bringing the political system closer to the people" promotes local democracy and political participation. This increase in local participation leads people to perceive more positively their political impact, as well as helps create lasting ties to formal institutions. Focusing on the broader institutional context that promoted the growth of indigenous autonomy, Yashar (2012) notes that the change from corporatist citizenship regimes to democratized neo-liberal spaces in the 1970s led to the possibility of indigenous groups organizing and gaining strength. Greater economic freedom achieved through neoliberal reforms decreased the government's control over indigenous economic activities, allowing them to become more independent. This increased autonomy led to increased community organization and unity, an important aspect in the development of the group's political power through bottom-up organizational development and autonomy from state intervention.

In contrast to highland indigenous groups, research on Afro-Ecuadorian politics highlights a different pattern of political incorporation. Jhon Antón Sánchez (2015) explains how Afro-Ecuadorians gained formal representation under the new constitution of Ecuador, which was introduced in 2008. This opened the door for multicultural reforms and state-sponsored development initiatives like CODAE (Afro-Ecuadorian Development Corporation). These communities have made great strides in recent years though, with new policies implemented by Rafael Correa increasing recognition by the state for Afro-Ecuadorians (Antón Sánchez 2015). Under these policies, Afro-Ecuadorian groups gained visibility became beneficiaries of development initiatives, but also set the standard of channeling Afro-Ecuadorian organizations through state-dependent structures, making them more dependent and less autonomous in the long run (de la Torre and Antón Sánchez 2018). This divergence in outcomes of community organizations reflects the purpose of this paper as a comparative analysis of the two groups.

Taken together, the literature identifies shared themes demonstrated in my hypothesis: the importance of territorially-rooted community structures, the origin of political organizations, and the nature of these organizations in relation to state politics. However, the literature treats the two groups separately, neglecting to infer a set of circumstances that account for the variation found today. The gap that this paper addresses is the comparative dimension. Current scholarship treats the groups individually, mapping their trajectories from similar origins but ending up at different conclusions. By comparing them within the same setting and framework, this paper hopes to identify community governance and collective organization as the mechanism explaining variation in political incorporation among the two minority groups.

Theory

Understanding the historical context and current involvement of minority groups in national Ecuadorian politics elucidates three factors that contribute to the variation: historical mode of incorporation, origin of political institutions, and relationship to the state.

Historical mode of incorporation

The participation of both Andean indigenous people and Afro-Ecuadorians throughout the history of the country has evolved due to external factors. Groups that are incorporated into

the state as territorially and communally rooted are more likely to develop strong autonomous community organizations. On the contrary, groups displaced from their territory and separated from their communities through slavery, coerced labor, and insecure land occupation face difficulties in building the same level of unity that leads to collective institutions, and thus autonomous political action groups.

Origin of political institutions

The way in which political institutions come about and the motivations behind their creation determine their long-term success and resilience. When organizations are created by the constituents themselves for their own motivations, the ideological strength increases and they are able to weather political change. On the contrary, organizations created by state and international intervention, although well-intended, are susceptible to funding cuts and political change. This lack of security detracts greatly from the organization's autonomy and continuation.

Relationship with the State

Groups with stronger social mobilization and power to sway national outcomes can gain a position of leverage against the state. Disruptions and mobilizations by these organizations increase their legitimacy and sustained representation in formal institutions. On the other hand, organizations mediated through state-assigned funding and bureaucracy are unable to create such mobilization without consequence.

Evidence

Using the three factors outlined above and the MSSD strategy, we can test the hypothesis above and understand the causal link to varying political incorporation between the two groups.

Historical Mode of Incorporation

The historical mode of incorporation of Andean indigenous groups is inextricably tied to territorial rights and labor structures. After colonization, indigenous populations worked on haciendas for wealthy landowners, but were granted legal status as self-governed communities through labor strikes in the 1930s and the Ley de Comunas. The community ownership and continuous land habitation paved the way for communities to organize politically on a

continuous basis, strengthening their autonomy and national influence over time. This history of communal governance has also contributed to an ethnic identity tied to traditional land ownership and right to autonomy, which persists in the group's political motivations today. In the context of Afro-Ecuadorian political incorporation, the group's history is much less conducive to a strongly organized political structure. Slaves and their posterity came into their lands through forced displacement and coerced labor, having no traditional ties to their land. Additionally, the lack of an event similar to the Ley de Comunas for the Andeans deprived the group of autonomous land ownership, condemning them to wage extraction on plantations for much of their history. This deprivation of formal rights and recognition stunted political organization and made it difficult for the group to find a common political ideology as the Andean groups have.

Origin of Political Institutions

Presently, both groups interact with national politics through ethnic organizations of varying national influence. The origin of those groups varies greatly, and can indicate why the disparity exists. Created in 1986, the Confederation of Indigenous Nationalities of Ecuador (CONAIE) emerged from a wave of regional organizing that sought to unify diverse peoples into a single, nationwide movement with its own political aims and autonomous institutions. CONAIE is currently the most powerful political organization of indigenous peoples in Ecuador. CONAIE was founded upon the shared desire for land protection, preservation of cultural identity, and self-governance, and was formed from the unification of various grassroots efforts. The organization was formed without state intervention, in fact the opposite was the case. Indigenous people faced challenges in having their movement recognized by the state, demonstrating their determination and ideological/cultural strength.

Afro-Ecuadorians have also fought for their rights and organized in critical ways, but their key institutions have been shaped more directly by the state and international actors. After the 1998 Constitution recognized Afro-Ecuadorians as a collective with cultural and territorial rights, the government created the Corporación de Desarrollo Afroecuatoriano (CODAE) to promote development in Afro-Ecuadorian communities. CODAE and related bodies were state-funded and organized in a top-down approach. Cuts in funding, institutional instability, and alleged mismanagement have limited the effectiveness of the organization at achieving its aims.

The stark contrast between CONAIE and CODAE outcomes illustrates the theoretical claim that organizations developed from the bottom up through shared struggle and cultural unity develop into durable, autonomous organizations, whereas state-created interventions with similar goals become vulnerable and less effective.

Relationship with the State

The way in which our two cases interact with the state shows strong influence on how each one incorporates into national politics. Indigenous groups, organized at a community and national level through institutions such as CONAIE, have had consistently tumultuous relationships with the state. Events such as an attempted coup d'état in 2000 and consistent uprisings over various economic decisions during the last 40 years have created this legacy and given strong legitimacy to the demands set forth by the group. As a consequence of this pattern of social mobilization, CONAIE has strong sway over political decisions made at a national level. The state is forced to take the group's demands seriously out of fear of uprising and widespread disruption.

Afro-Ecuadorian political coalitions do not employ similar disruptive tactics. Instead, their interaction with the state is channeled primarily through institutions such as CODAE and through development and anti-racism programs negotiated with ministries and international donors. In practice, this means that state-appointed representatives manage and operate CODAE programs to plan, implement, and evaluate development programs. Other avenues include collective rights and anti-racism programs negotiated and funded by international donors. Afro-Ecuadorian communities do engage in protests and local resistance efforts, but as noted by Antón Sánchez, these efforts are localized and issue-specific.

Across these three factors, a consistent pattern is revealed. Andean indigenous communities maintained territorially-rooted community structures into the modern period, struggling against state actors and creating political institutions from the bottom up. Afro-Ecuadorian communities on the other hand experienced a history of forced displacement and insecure land rights and saw their main political avenues created and funded by state-managed efforts. These differences map closely onto the theoretical explanation that organizational autonomy and communal leverage against the state produces more impactful political incorporation.

Analysis

The evidence from the two cases supports the core hypothesis that the variation in political incorporation between the two groups has been directly shaped by three factors: (1) historical mode of incorporation, (2) origin of political institutions, and (3) relationship with the state. Together, these factors help explain why Andean indigenous and Afro-Ecuadorian minority groups exhibit differing levels of impact and involvement in national politics in Ecuador. Indigenous groups' continuous retention of territory and cultural identity, bottom-up institutional creation, and large-scale mobilization efforts have enabled them to press their political demands more effectively and autonomously across electoral cycles and periods of political change.

For Afro-Ecuadorians, by contrast, a history of slavery and continued marginalization after abolition limited the retention of territory and community identity in ways that differ from Andean Indigenous communities. The political institutions currently utilized by the Afro-Ecuadorian community were largely created from above and remained dependent on state budgets and donor priorities, leaving them unstable and ineffective across electoral cycles. Combined with a lower capacity to mobilize on a large scale, this state-mediated mode of incorporation remains vulnerable.

While this theory provides a plausible causal link between these three factors and political incorporation, there are additional dynamics beyond the scope of this analysis. Geographical differences between the two communities shape economic opportunities and development patterns. Racism against people of African descent, although discussed in historical terms in this theory, is still occurring today ("Ecuador: Discrimination and Environmental Racism"). This ongoing reality arguably contributes significantly to current patterns of political access and representation at the national level and should be examined more fully in future research.

Conclusion

This paper answers the question of variation in political incorporation through elucidating three causes, suggesting that historical modes of incorporation, origin and motivation of created political institutions, and patterns of community-state interaction play a central role in the outcome of political autonomy for minority groups. More broadly, this analysis shows that state

intervention through legal precedent and top-down organizational structures are not sufficient on their own to propel a group to durable political autonomy. When communities build and sustain autonomous organizations independent of state funding and donor agendas, a stronger sense of political unity and influence on a national level is achieved.

Importantly, this comparison does not imply political deficiency on the part of Afro-Ecuadorian communities, instead highlighting how a legacy of forced displacement, insecure land tenure, and later forms of state-mediated incorporation has constrained the development of organizational autonomy and contentious leverage, even in the presence of formal constitutional rights. Contemporary manifestations of this legacy include social prejudice and socioeconomic conditions such as concentrated poverty and violence in coastal provinces, which further complicate large-scale organizing. The comparison outlined in this paper suggests that states should pay close attention to how they interact with minority groups and the impact that both their action and inaction can have on political autonomy and collective rights. Understanding the need for independence and an orchestration of circumstances to make that independence a reality should be the focus of political development efforts, rather than the type of direct imposition that perpetuates instability and ineffectiveness.

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